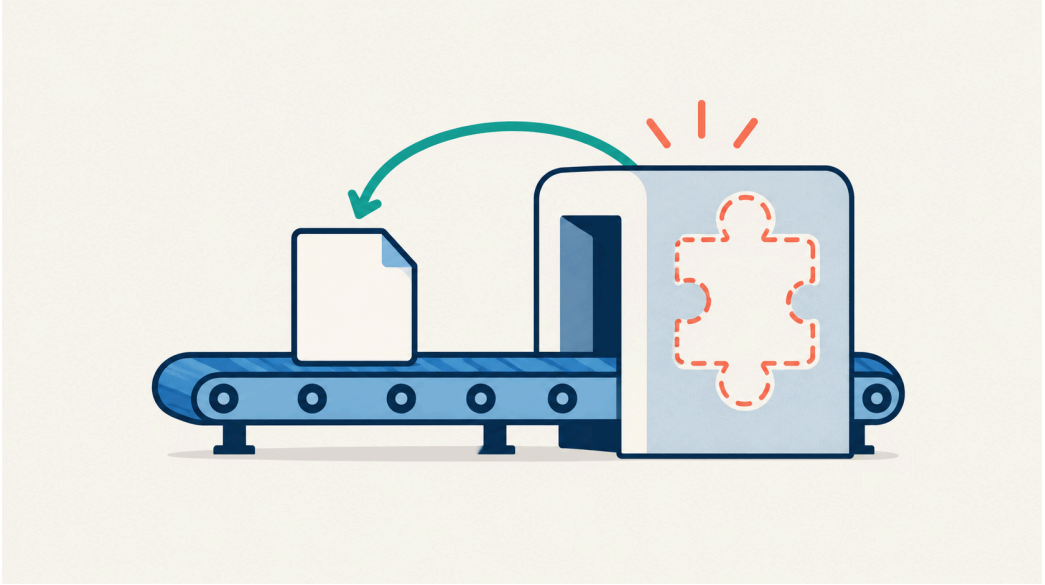
The Missing Test Suite

Where the bottleneck goes when code is cheap

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Early in the project, we had to decide: workflow or agent?

Worth a talk of its own: Workflow or Agent.
Today we take it as fixed: we built a workflow.

Code is cheap now.
So what becomes the bottleneck?

On a support automation I built: the experts who could tell whether a reply was right.

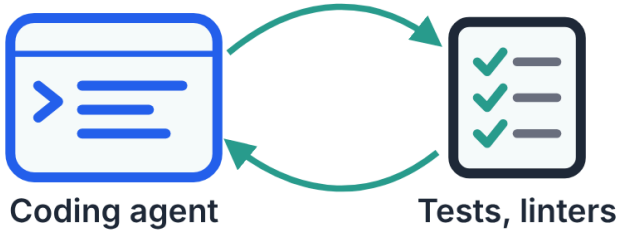
Why coding agents work

1. **Software is familiar.** Syntax, idioms and libraries are patterns the model has seen countless times in training.
2. **Every attempt gets a verdict.** Tests, linters and error messages tell the agent whether it worked, so the agentic loop runs without a human in it.

A reply to a customer has no test suite

- Code: the verdict comes **on every attempt**, for free.
- A reply: the verdict comes **when an expert reads it**.
- The model hasn't seen your escalation rules or your customers' records either.

Code



Reply to a customer



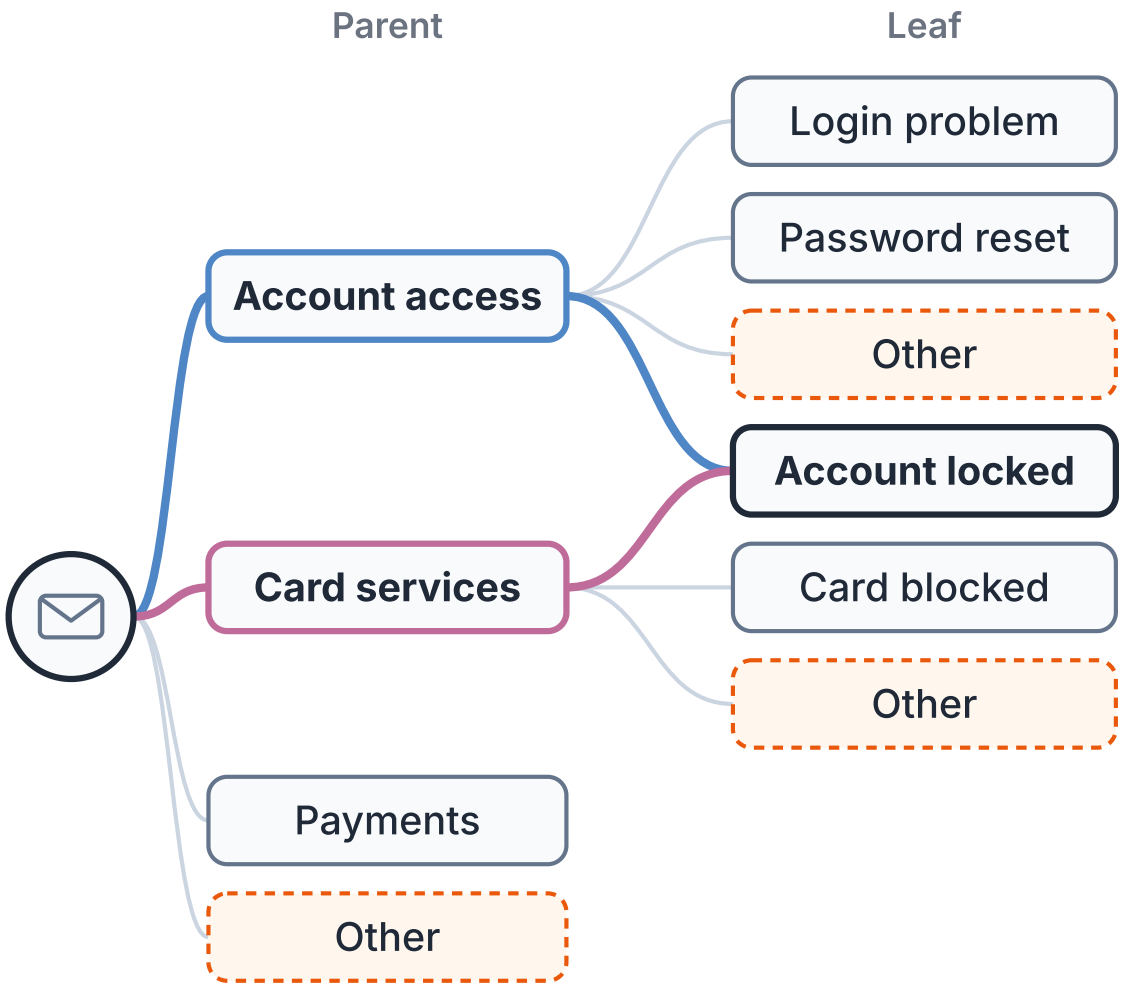
The running example

Customer · 2026-03-12 09:41

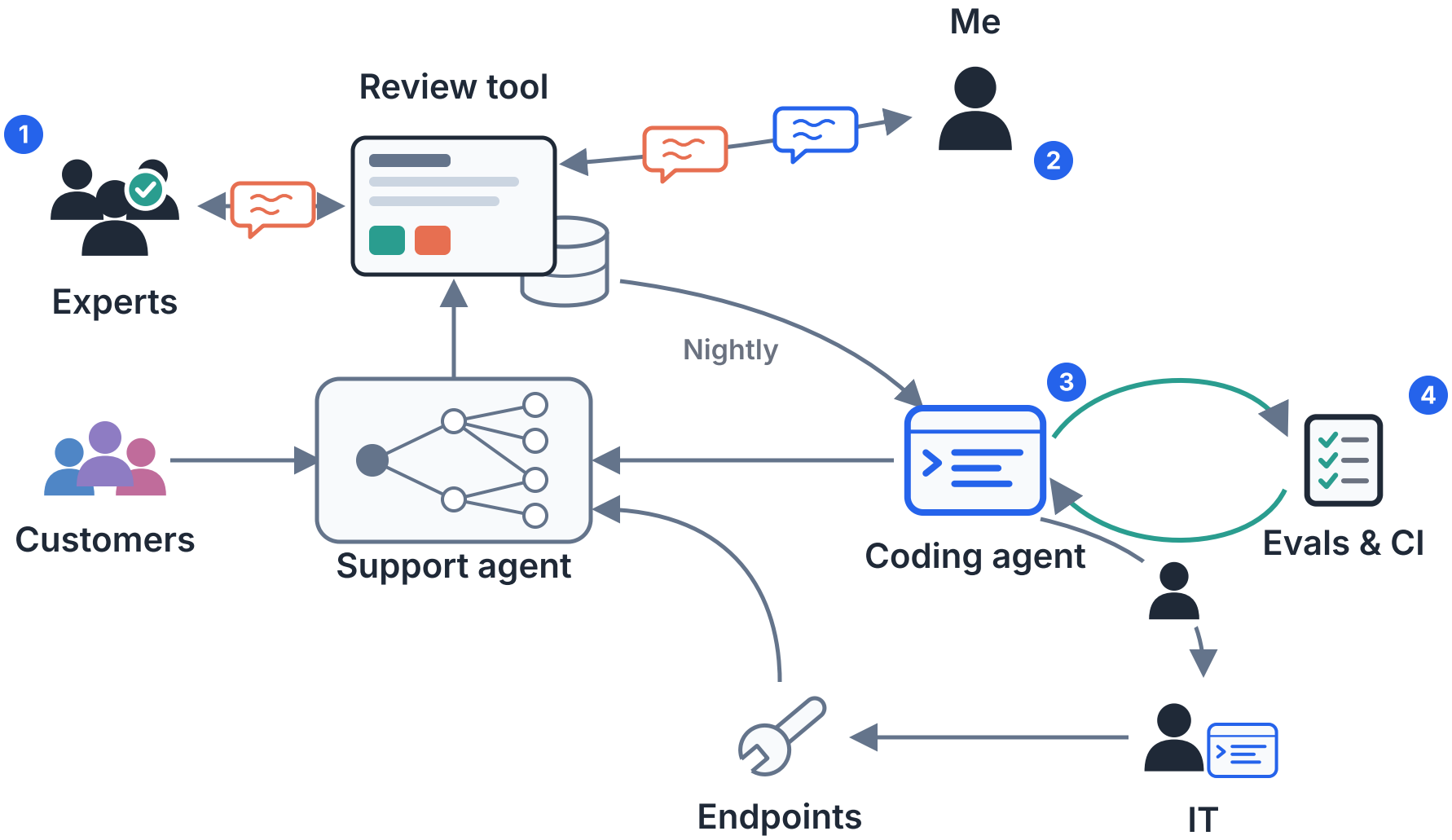
Hi, I'm Alex Carter and I bank with your Riverton branch. My account number is NSB01234 and I can't get in any more; it keeps saying the account is locked. Can you help me get back in?

Invented to protect the client; the project behind it is real.

The workflow: the model picks the request, code decides what happens

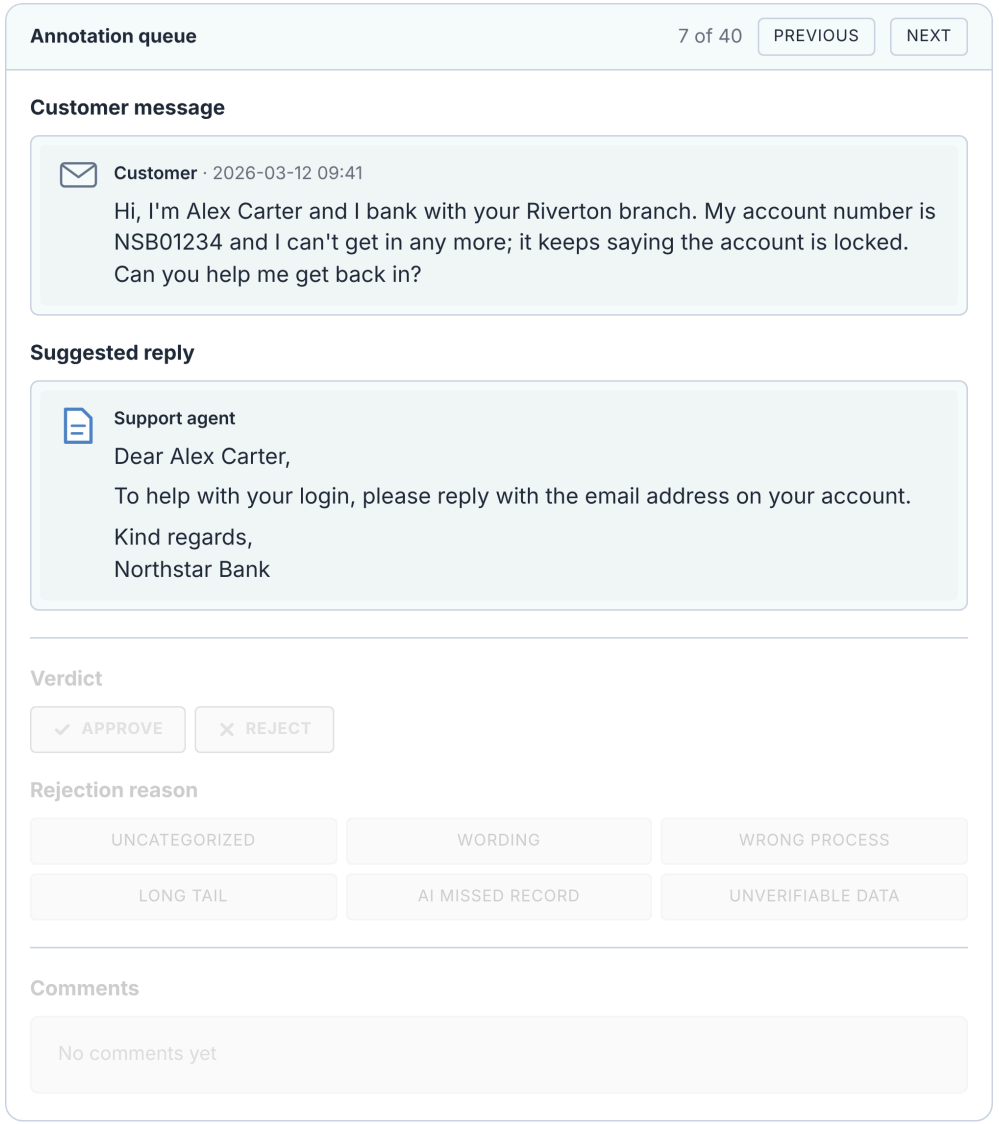


The whole system



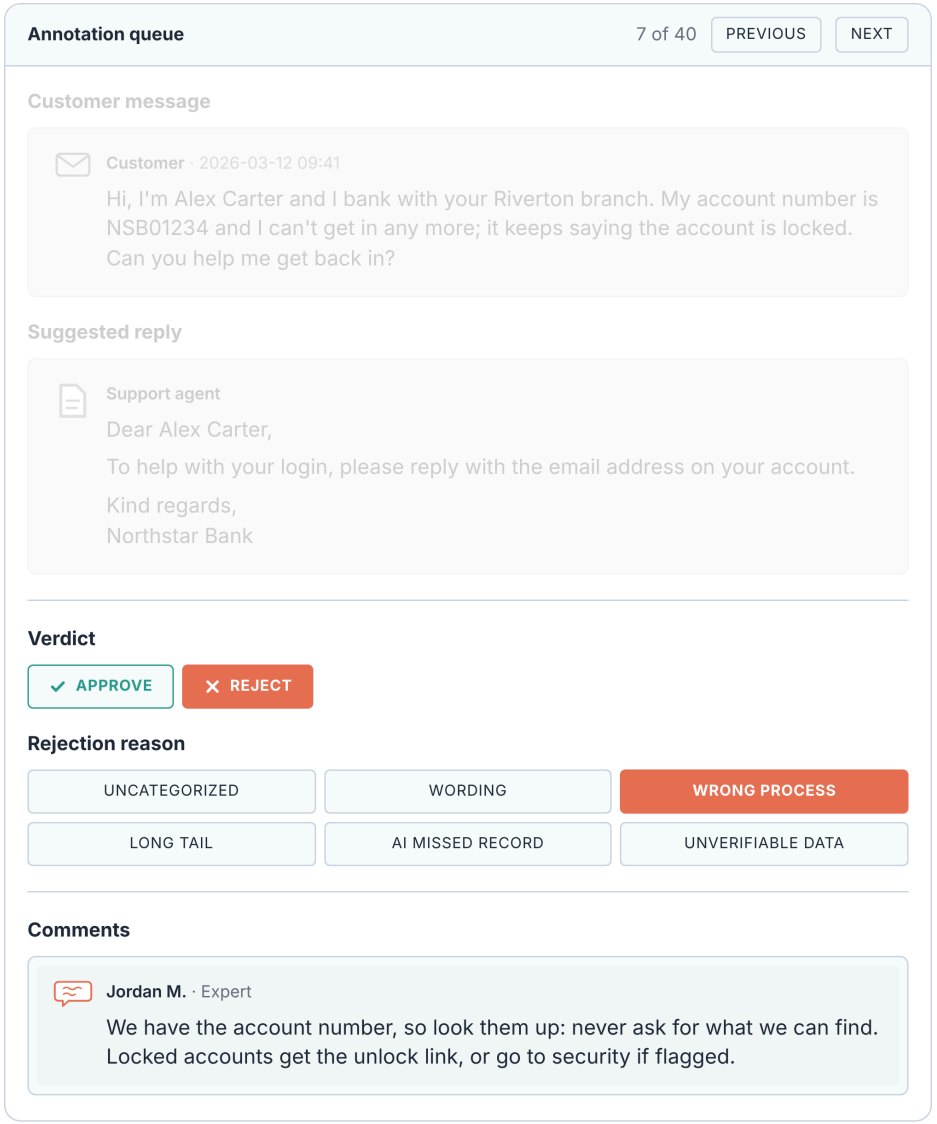
Step 1: experts grade

- The customer’s message and the proposed reply, nothing else.
- Shadow deployment: a draft for every real ticket, none sent.
- Graded when the expert picks up the ticket anyway.
- An approved draft is a reply they don’t have to write.



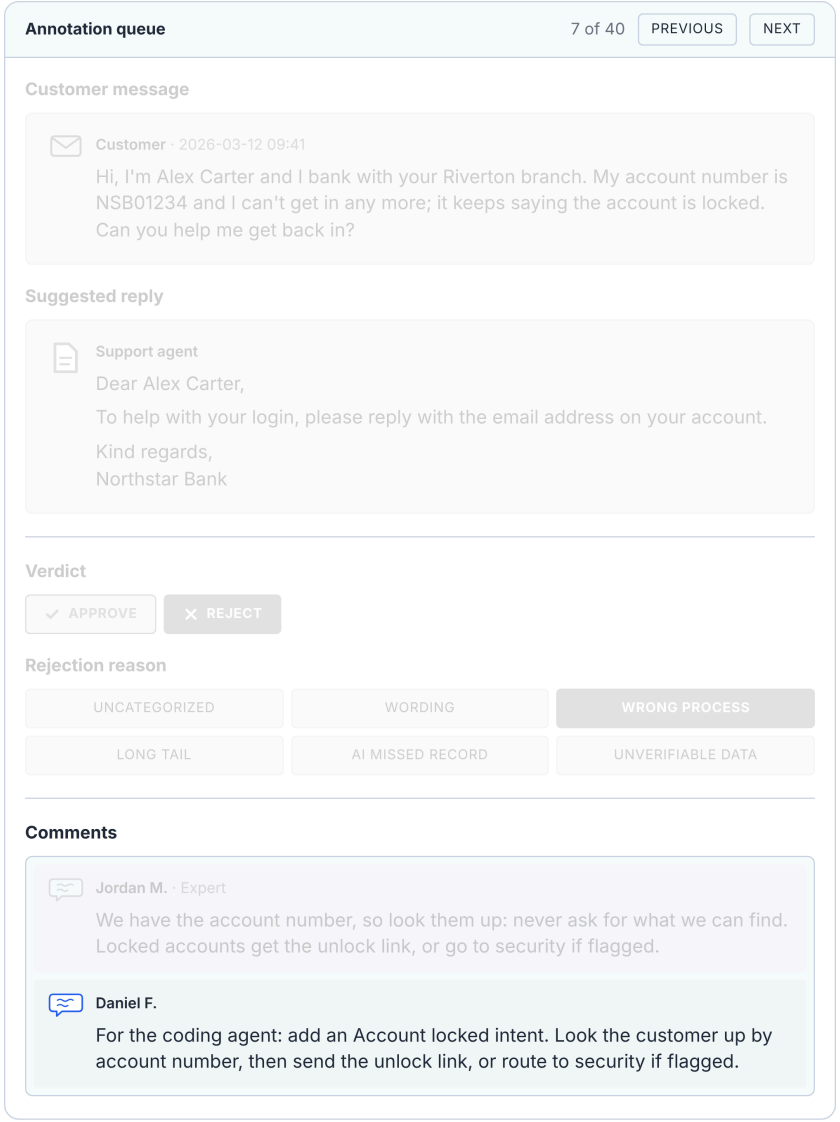
One rejection, two rules nobody had written down

- **Never ask for what we can find.**
- **Locked accounts get the unlock link, or go to security if flagged.**
- Grading is the check a coding agent gets from its tests, and how the rules get written down.

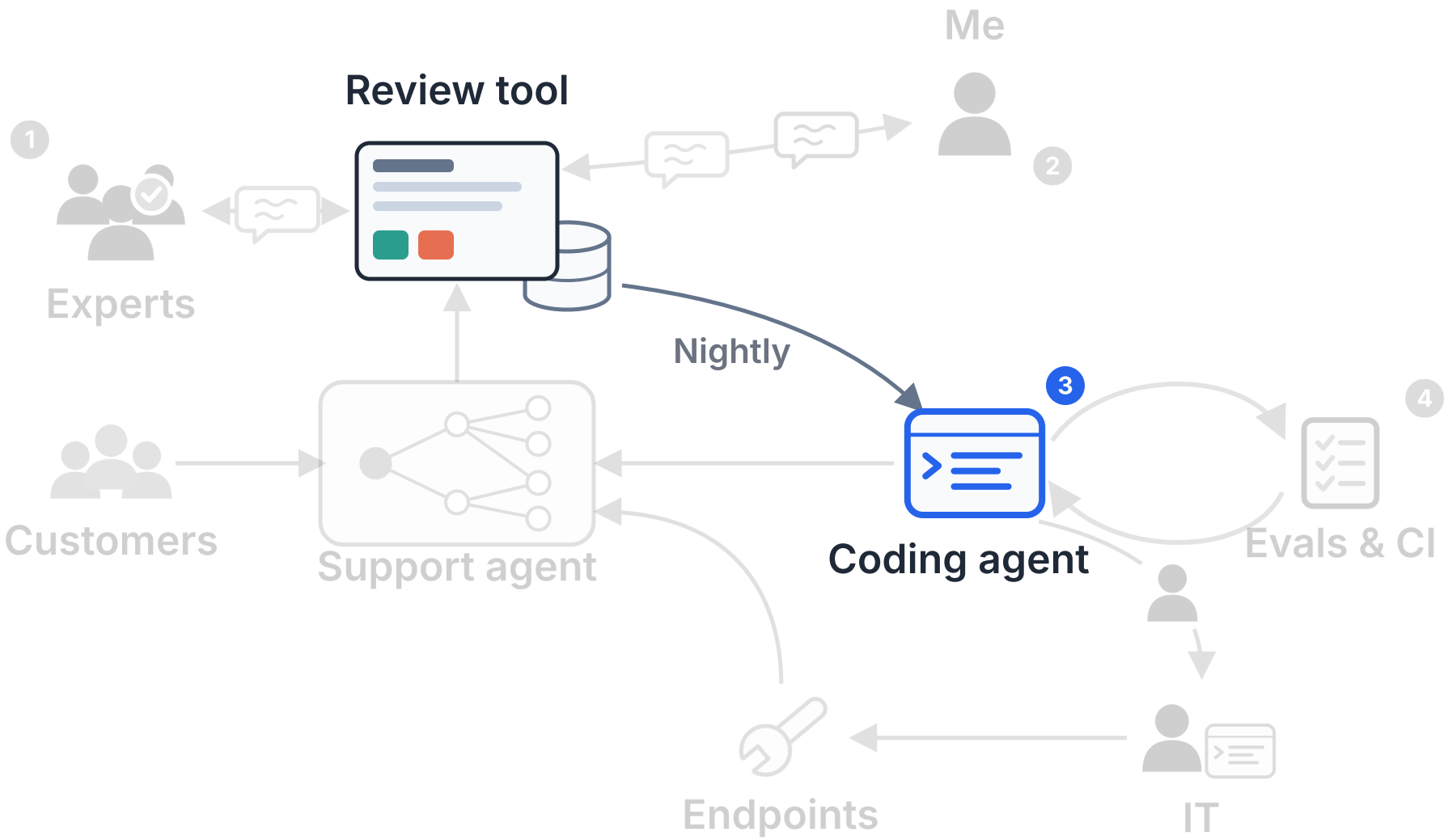


Step 2: I specify the fix

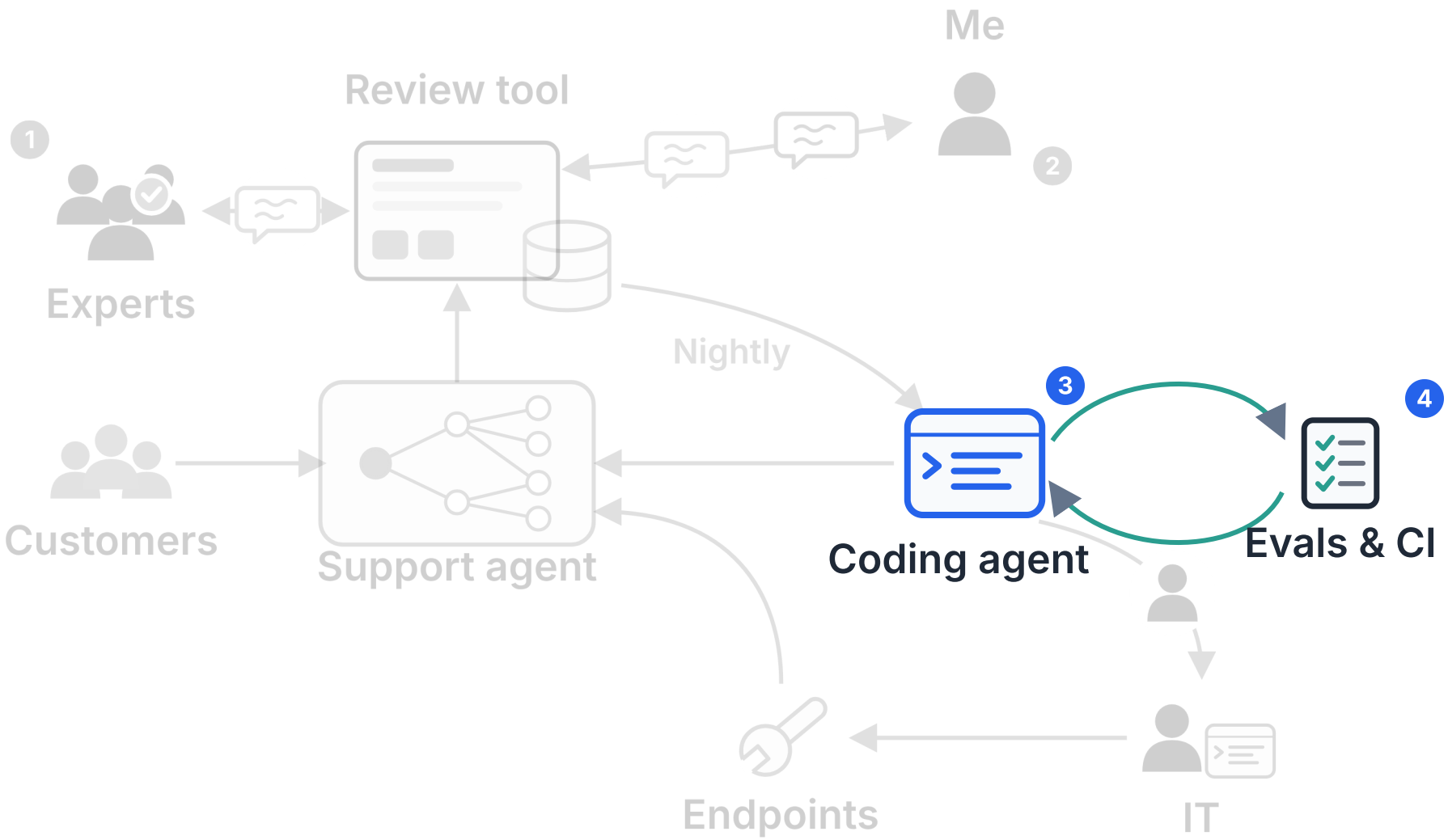
- In one sitting, for a batch of feedback.
- A plan for the coding agent next to the expert’s comment: where the fix goes, what it does.
- Follow-up questions go in the tool, next to the ticket.



Step 3: the coding agent implements it overnight

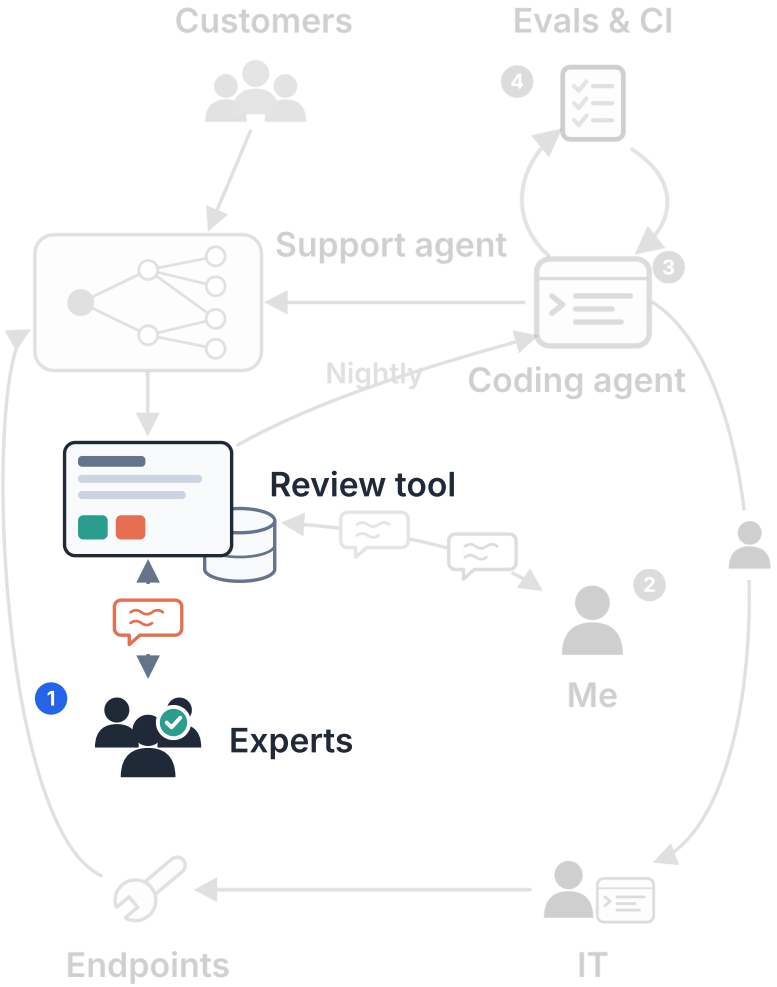


Step 4: evals and CI check it



The factory checks against my plan; only an expert checks against the business

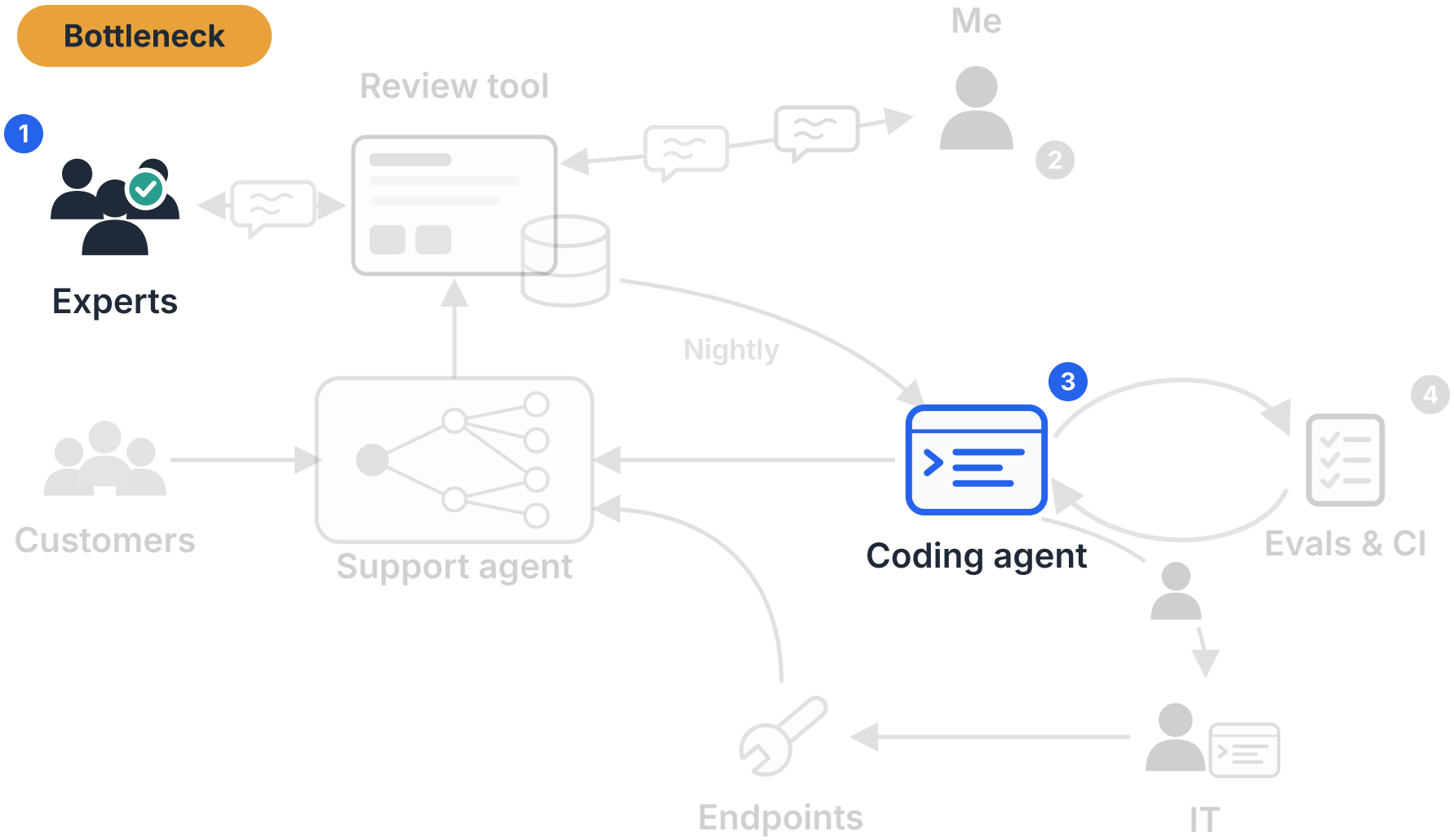
- The eval case is written from **my** plan.
- A green build says the code does what I asked, not that I asked for the right thing.
- So I resubmit the rejected ticket, and an expert checks the new draft.



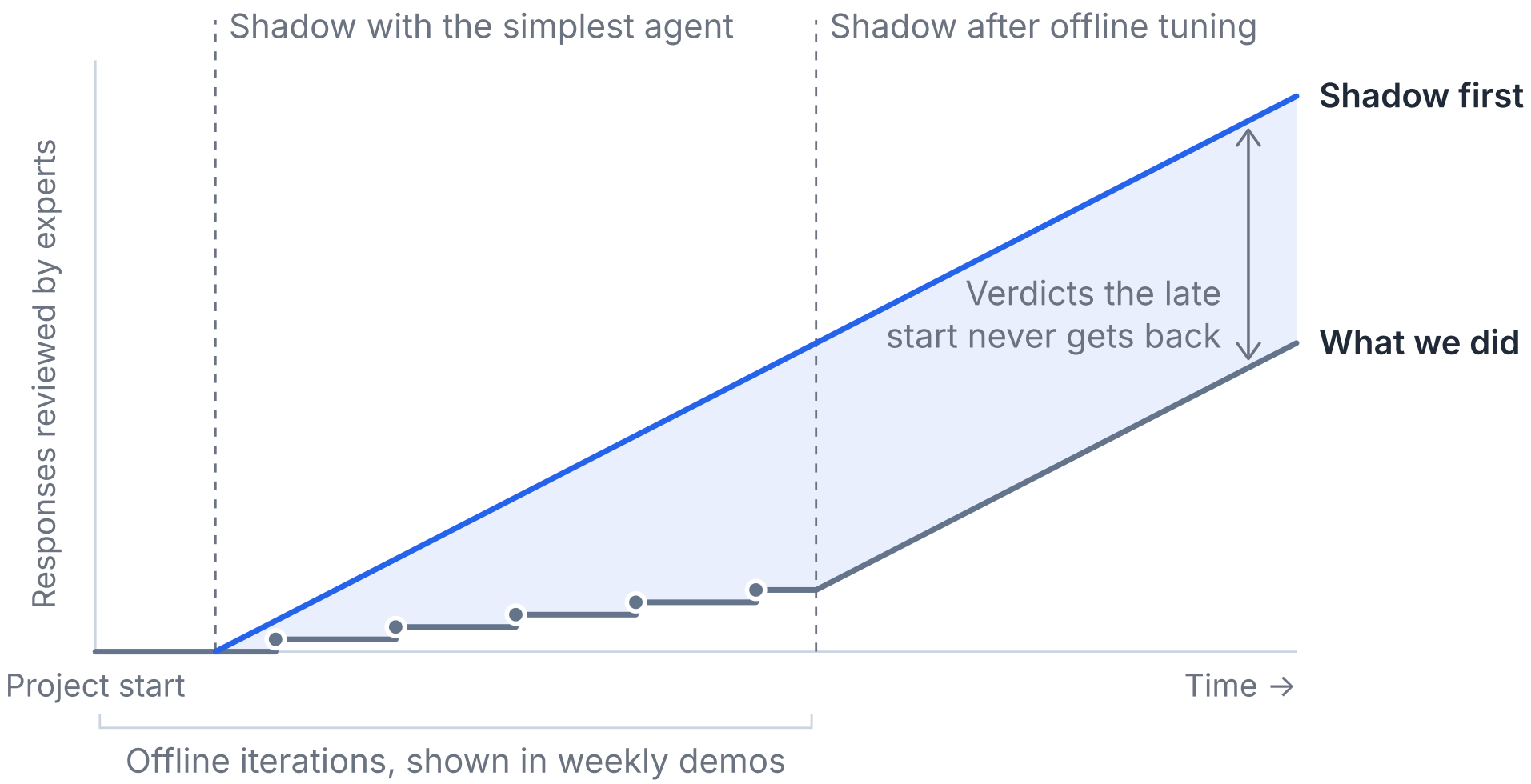
Every system has a bottleneck.
Fixing it doesn’t remove it; it moves it.

Eliyahu Goldratt, theory of constraints

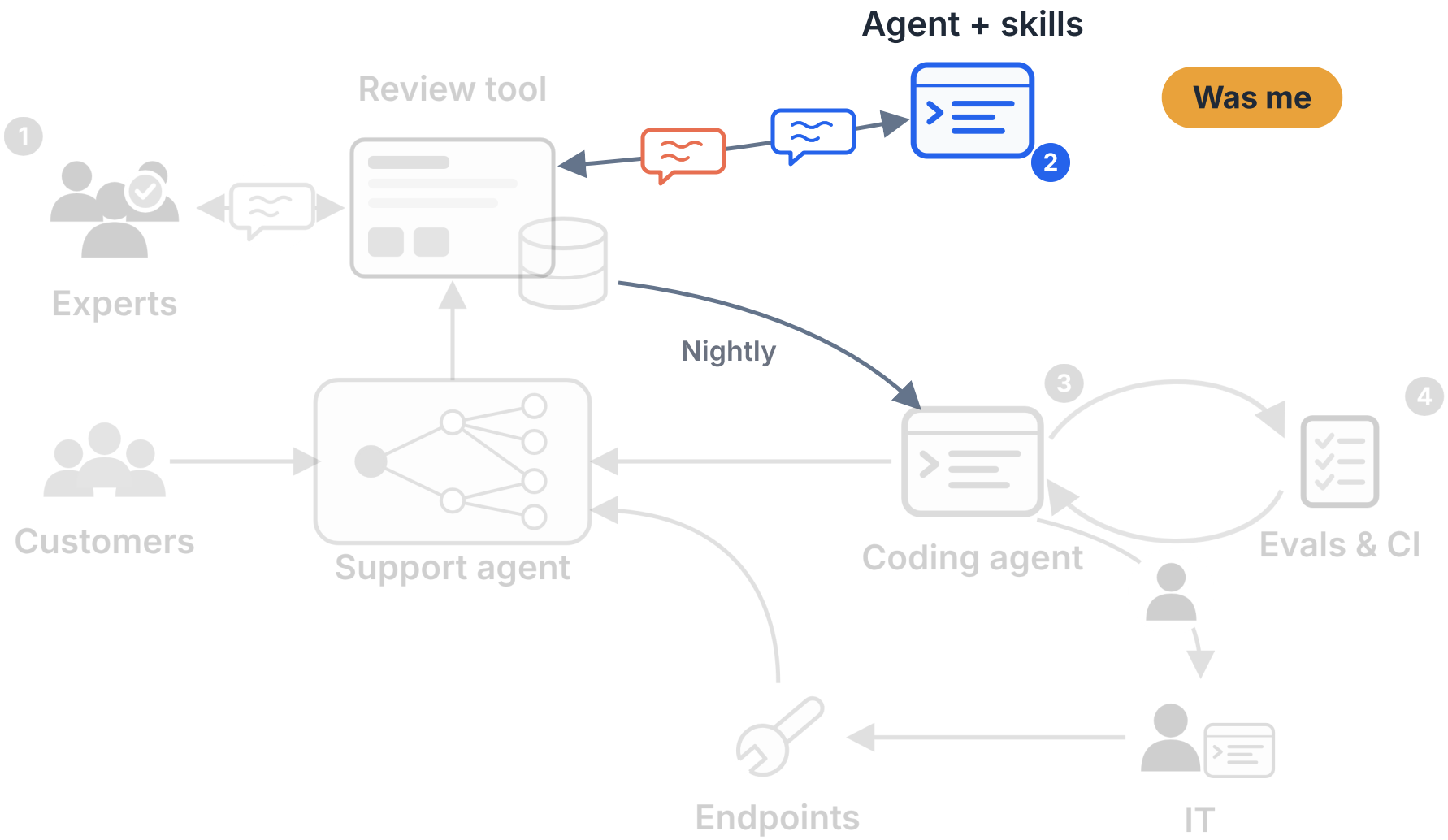
With coding agents: the experts' time sets the pace



Get into shadow deployment sooner



The next bottleneck: who translates the feedback



Start at the bottleneck

1. **Settle what the loop should improve**, and what that would save.
2. **Build the review screen and shadow deployment first**, with the simplest system that can draft a reply behind it.
3. **Then grow the rules from the grades**, not from a whiteboard.

Until someone who knows the business reads the output every day, every design decision is a guess.

danielfridljand.de/post/the-missing-test-suite